

Q Do I need to buy extra stroller accessories or are they really a waste of money?

There are a few useful extra items that are worth considering if you want to buy, especially if you intend to be out in all weathers.

Transparent rain covers, which attach directly onto the carriage or stroller, can give your baby complete protection from wind and rain. Air passes beneath and through side air vents so your baby can breathe easily even while the cover remains fixed in place. Foot muffs are cosy for chilly days. Some manufacturers include this as part of the model, or you can buy a foot muff separately. On sunny days, a parasol or shade attachment will help to keep your baby protected from the sun. Very small babies often need a head support, or head hugger, that fits around their head, stopping it from lolling to the side; these can be used in car seats as well as strollers.

Q I like the idea of carrying my baby in a sling and being hands-free. Which ones give enough support for newborns?

Front carriers and baby slings will support a newborn baby, although you need to take more care if using a sling. Front carriers hold your baby upright against your body, have safety restraints, and are suitable for newborns weighing at least 7½ lb (3.5 kg). Your baby can either face inward toward you, and then when older, can face outward. Choose fabrics that can be easily cleaned and look for styles that provide good support for your baby, have broad, comfortable shoulder straps, and if possible a hip strap, so that your baby's weight is evenly distributed across your back.

Baby slings and baby wraps are made from soft, flexible fabric. Some can be worn over your shoulder in a cradle hold; others can be adapted to hold your baby in different positions. There have been safety concerns around baby slings, that babies can suffocate if carried incorrectly. Make sure you can see your baby's face at all times, he is held as high up on your chest as possible, he is held securely against your body, and his chin isn't touching his chest, as this could hamper his breathing; and his back and neck are well supported.

Q We don't drive much. Is a car seat essential for newborns and babies?

Even if you rarely make car trips, the law states that your baby must be in a properly installed car seat for all car trips, even if this is just in the taxi on the way home from the hospital.

It's recommended that your baby's car seat is rear facing until your baby reaches the correct weight for the type of car seat you are using—see the guideline table (right). In the event of a collision your baby's head and spine will be better protected; if he is in a forward-facing seat, any sudden forward movement could seriously damage his weak neck muscles and ligaments.

A baby shouldn't spend more than a couple of hours at a time sitting in a car seat, since the semi-upright position can compress a young baby's chest, which can lead to breathing difficulties and damage his developing spine.

Safety standards

When purchasing a new car seat, look for a good rating from the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA). Choose a seat with a five-point safety harness, which offers optimum safety, and follow the manufacturer's instructions when installing and using it.

Your baby may outgrow your infant car seat, for height and weight, at around 9 to 12 months. He still needs to sit in a rear-facing seat. For his next car seat, purchase a convertible or all-in-one car seat, which has higher height and weight limits. Your baby can use this seat for a couple of years, and eventually, the seat can be turned around so it's forward facing. The NHTSA recommends keeping babies rear facing for as long as possible—until three years old—for safety's sake.

INFANT CAR SEAT GUIDELINES

Car seats are classified into groups based on your baby's weight. Your child will move into the next car seat group when he has reached the weight limit for his seat, or his eye line is level with the top of the seat.

SEAT	DESCRIPTION
Infant car seat	This is the ideal car seat to bring with you to the hospital. It should last you until your baby is about nine months old, give or take.
Convertible car seat	Babies stay rear facing until they're at least two years old, based on weight limits. Then seats can be turned around.
All-in-one car seat	These seats are intended to be used for every stage of your baby's childhood. They can accommodate babies as small as 4 lb (1.8 kg) and can be used for children as old as 10 years.

Car seat This is an essential piece of equipment, and because of strict safety regulations it should be bought new.

